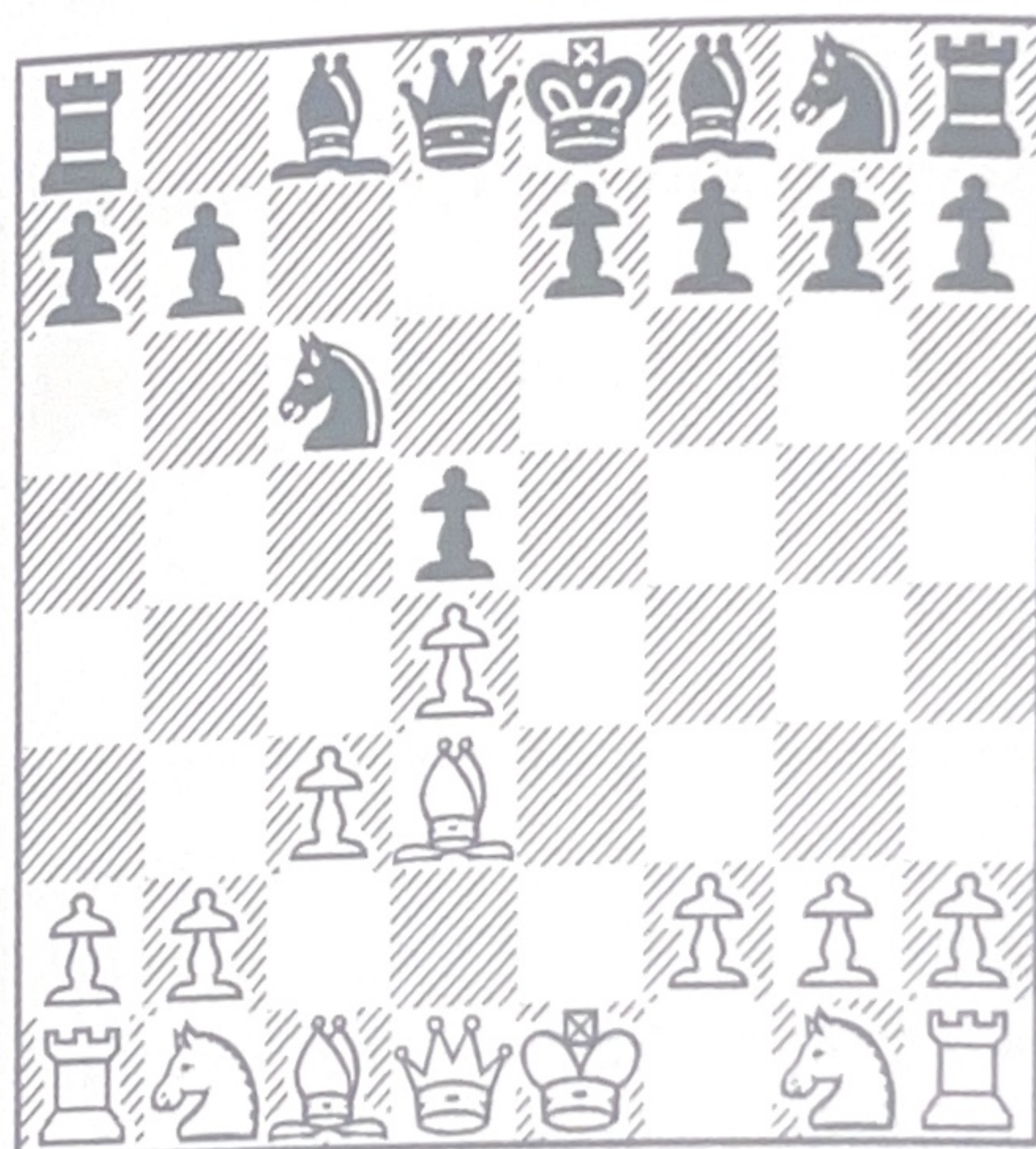


Chapter Eight

The Exchange Variation

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 exd5 cxd5 4 ♖d3 ♘c6 5 c3



The Exchange Variation was thought to be one of the most harmless lines against the Caro until Bobby Fischer utilized it to beat former world champion Tigran Petrosian in 1970. Although not quite as harmless as it appears, the line is popular (particularly on the Internet) because of its easy and direct strategy based on very classical ideas of development.

The Asymmetrical Pawn Structure

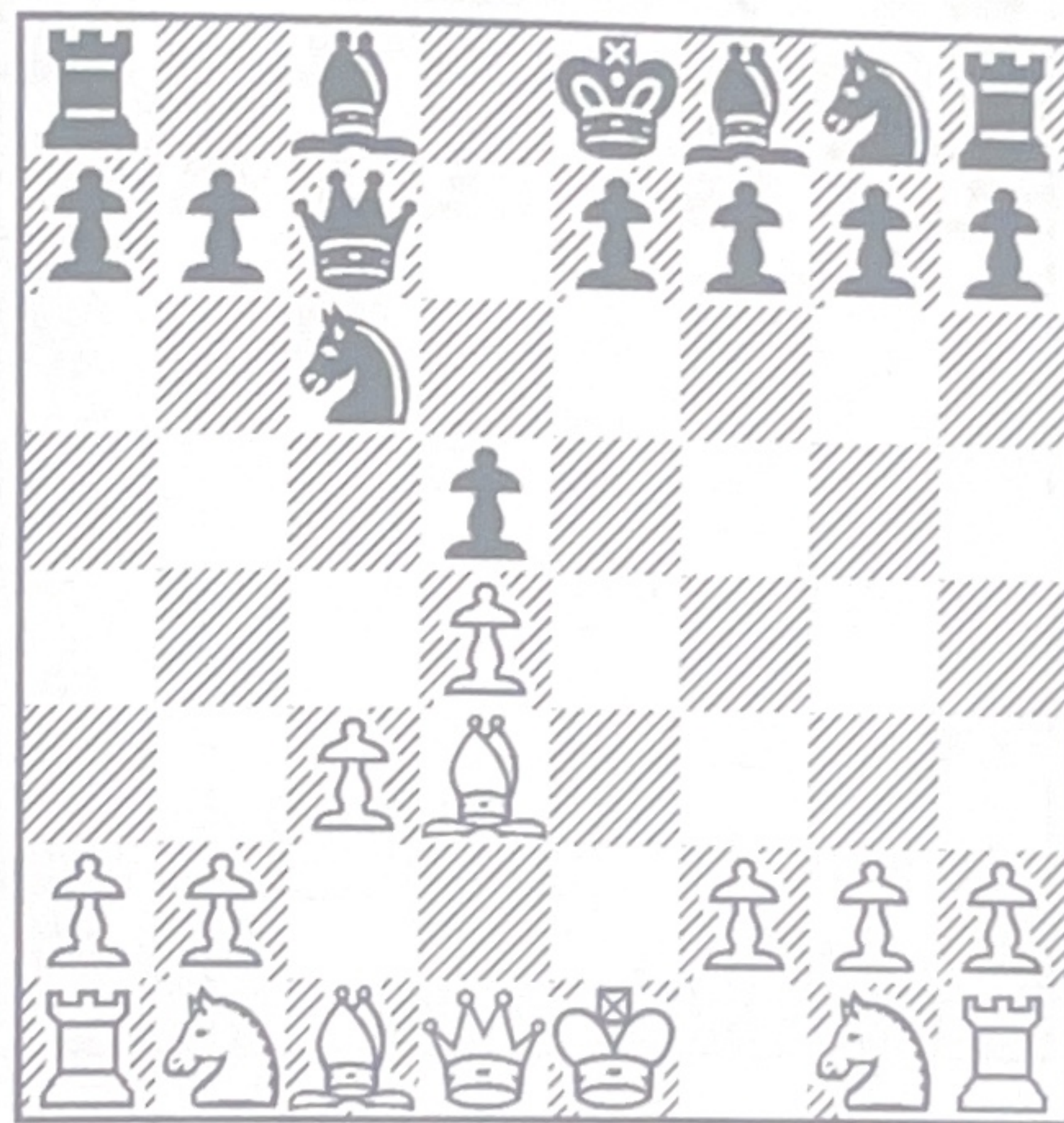
The asymmetrical pawn structure to a certain extent determines the play. White's plan in the opening stages is certainly very simple: to develop the bishops to d3 and f4, the queen follows to c2 or maybe b3, and then the f3-knight will launch itself into e5, right where those central pawns are pointing. After this, White can merrily begin a kingside attack.

The long-term plan for Black is to focus his middlegame efforts on the queenside using what is known as the *minority attack*, where the two queenside pawns advance up the board hoping to saddle White with a backward pawn and less space. This advance is particularly dangerous if Black has deposited a knight on the c4-square. The idea is usually seen when the centre has reached a standstill – either when there is maximum tension (i.e. both sets of pieces have reached their potential), or minimum tension (the majority of the minor pieces have been swapped off).

That summarizes the basic aim of the opening for both sides, but to begin with Black has to fight two opening battles: the first is to gain control over the e5-square and the second is to find a role for the light-squared bishop. The latter can indeed be a fundamental problem, for if White plays ♞d3 and h2-h3 then where indeed does the problematic bishop go?

The First Battle: the e5-square

Both sides have a strong square which they will seek to control and occupy, often before beginning their respective attacks. For White it is the important e5-square and for Black it is c4. For this reason it is vital that Black gets his move order right. His first task is to prevent the dark-squared bishop developing to f4, so we should see the following move order: $4 \text{ ♞d3} \text{ ♟c6! } 5 \text{ c3} \text{ ♚c7!?}$ ($5 \dots \text{♞f6}$ is another traditional line, but here White will play 6 ♞f4! controlling e5 – don't do what I did at the Olympiad this year when I paused, remembered that $\dots \text{♞f6}$ is possible and suddenly my hand had made the move for me).



With $5 \dots \text{♚c7}$ Black signals to White that is prepared to contest the e5-square. Now the opening battle may revolve around White kicking the queen off this important diagonal or he may simply ignore this slight hiccup and continue as normal. The e5-square will become a hotbed of tension and can become tremendously important should White fail to control e5 at all.

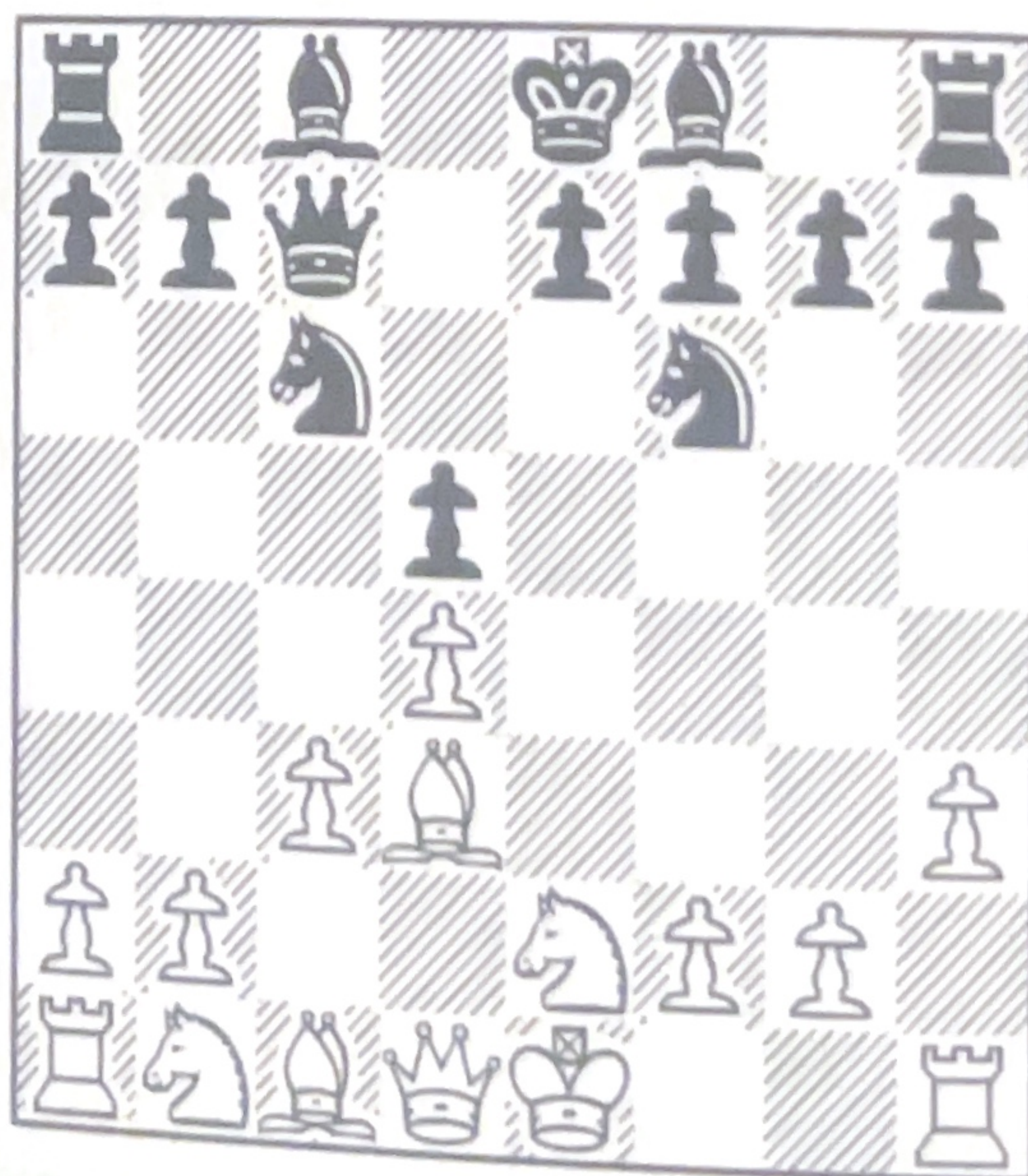
In fact we can even formulate a very important rule: *if White has neglected his develop-*

ment and doesn't make any effort to control the centre with $\Delta g1-f3$, we should strike out with the dynamic pawn push $\dots e7-e5$.

Indeed, just take a look at the following examples:



Here White has just played 8 $\Delta f4$ (note the placing of the white knight on e2) when the correct move is 8...e5!. Do not forget this rule! I once did to my regret and in a game against GM Stuart Conquest.



Stuart has just played 7 $\Delta e2$. I didn't appreciate the strength of the $\dots e7-e5$ idea and tried the inaccurate 7...g6?!. Of course I should have played 7...e5! with an excellent position.

Finally, we should consider 6 $\Delta g5$ $\Delta f6$ 7 $\Delta xf6$ gxf6 8 $\Delta f3$.



Now Black has the surprising 8...e5!, something, as you will see later, which gives Black a marvellous position. It is an important move to remember as it forms the tactical basis for going 5...♔c7.

The Second Battle: the c8-bishop

Rather like in the Queen's Gambit Declined, we should consider ourselves very happy if we can develop the light-squared bishop outside the pawn chain, especially to the g4-square. However, Black still has to be careful even when the bishop arrives at its desired square. The first danger is that a bishop sitting on g4 can become vulnerable to a ♖e2-♖g3 manoeuvre, as in a situation like the following.



White has just played 7 ♖b3, escaping from the pin, and now the bishop is in danger of being trapped out there on g4 after 7...e6 8 ♖g3, so Black should simply play 7...♗xe2.

Neutralizing the ♖d3 and ♔c2 Diagonal Attack

White can often exert uncomfortable pressure along the b1-h7 diagonal. However, this pressure can be easily neutralized with a bishop retreat to g6.



Here Black should simply play 10...♗h5! preparing ...♗g6 which should neutralize any potential danger, while copying White's own bishop manoeuvre.

White Prevents ...♗g4

Sometimes White plays an early h2-h3 so that Black cannot develop the bishop to the desired g4-square. Usually in such situations, Black will react by fianchettoing with ...g7-g6 and forcing the exchange of the bishops on f5. So, for instance, we might see:

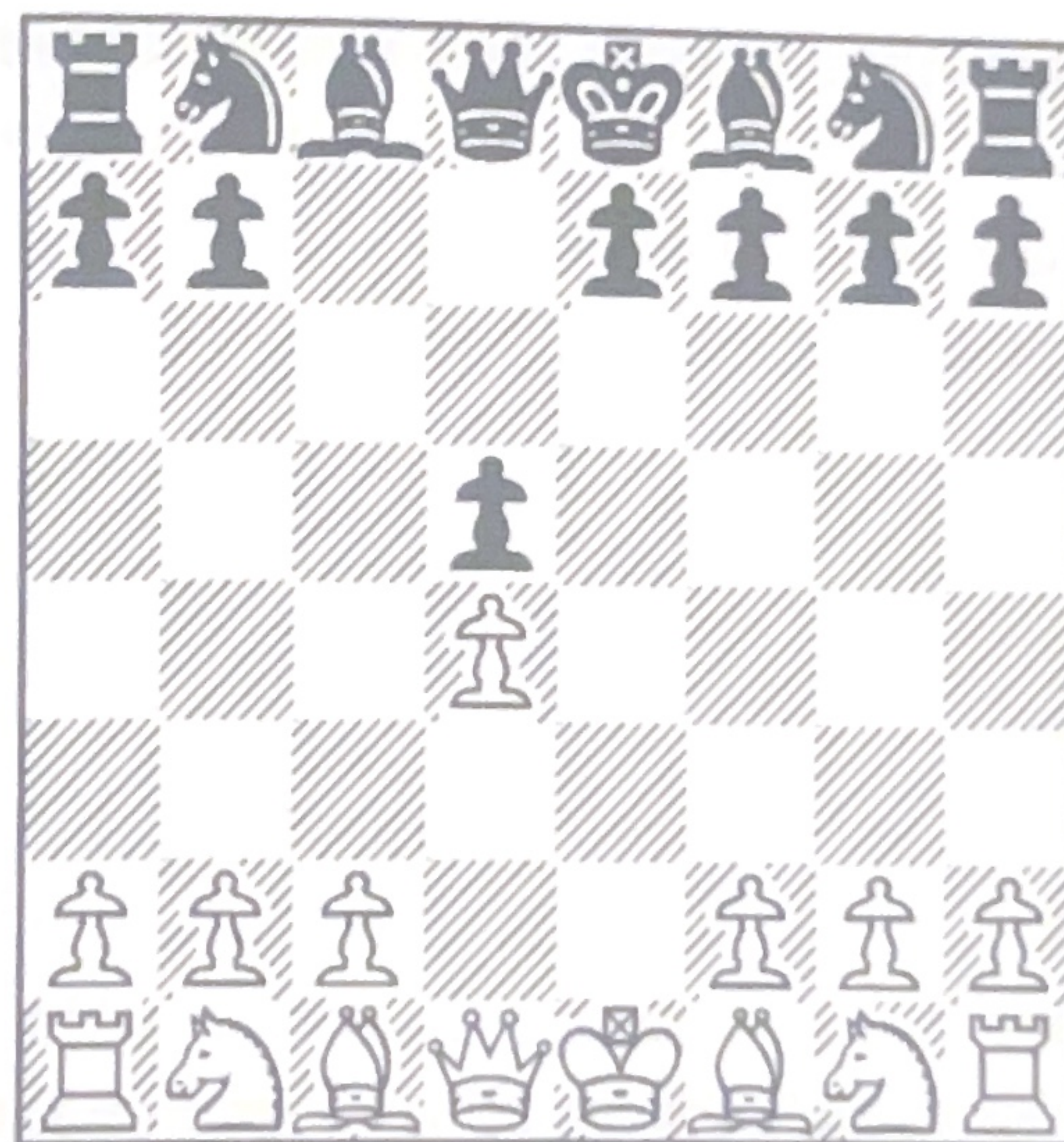


White might, however, be smarter and prevent this concept with ♔c2.



Now the bishop can't go to g4 or f5, but there is a downside to White's play, one we can exploit with 10...♘h5, aiming for ...♘f4, after which White will not be able to stop us from releasing the bishop.

1 e4 c6 2 d4 d5 3 exd5 cxd5



4 ♗d3

Standard, if not the only move available to White:

a) 4 ♘f3 ♘f6 5 ♗f4!? (preventing ...♙c7; after 5 ♗d3 Black plays 5...♗g4 and 5 ♘e5 g6 transposes to Line E in our final chapter) 5...♘c6 6 c3 ♗f5 7 ♘bd2 (or 7 ♘e5 ♘d7 8 ♗d3 ♗xd3 9 ♘xd3 e6 10 0-0 ♗e7 11 ♘d2 0-0 12 ♘f3 ♘f6 and Black doesn't really have any serious problems; he has the long-term plan of staging a minority attack on the queenside while White is lacking a light-squared bishop to damage our kingside with) 7...e6 8 ♙b3 ♙c8 9 ♘h4 ♗e4 10 f3 ♗g6 11 g4 ♗e7 12 ♘xg6 hxg6 13 ♗d3 ♘d7 14 0-0 (E.Sveshnikov-

D.Arnggrimsson, Albena 2013) 14...♗d8 and Black will reroute the bishop to c7.

b) 4 ♗f4 ♘c6 5 c3 ♗f6 6 ♗d3 ♗g4 7 ♖b3 ♖c8 8 ♗d2 e6 9 ♗gf3 ♗e7 10 0-0 ♗h5 (getting ready to challenge the key diagonal) 11 ♗e5 ♗xe5 12 ♗xe5 0-0 with easy development.
4...♗c6 5 c3 ♖c7



I am sticking with my original recommendation. White now has three major plans. He will try to:

a) Stop our c8-bishop developing outside the pawn chain even at the cost of neglecting development.

b) Disrupt our development with a timely ♗g5.

c) Gain control over the f4-square.

Thus we will focus on:

A) 6 h3!

B) 6 ♗g5

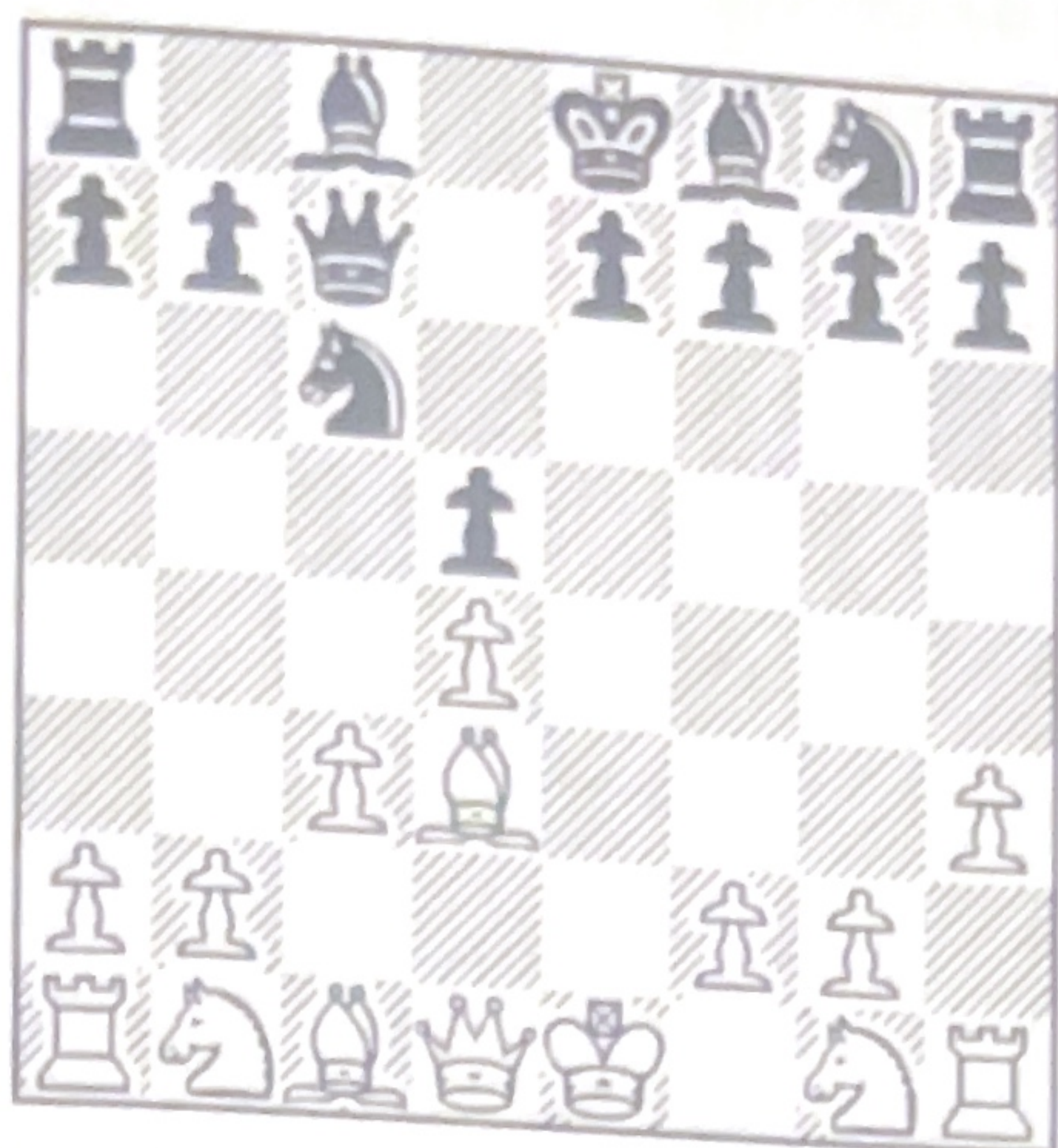
C) 6 ♗e2

Other unusual options are:

a) 6 f4 and here we should follow Schandorff's recommendation with 6...♗h6 7 ♗f3 ♗f5 8 0-0 e6 9 ♗e5 ♗d6 10 ♖e2 0-0 11 ♗e3 ♖ae8 12 ♗d2 f6 13 ♗xc6 bxc6, with a pleasant position in M.Rusanov-A.Shimanov, Peterhof 2007.

b) 6 ♗d2 ♗f6 7 ♗gf3 ♗g4 8 0-0 e6 9 ♖e1 ♗d6 10 ♗f1 (with the aim of playing ♗g3 and winning the bishop-pair) 10...0-0 11 ♗g3 (after 11 ♗g5 ♗d7 12 ♗h4 ♗h5 13 ♗g3 ♗g6 Black is completely equal; there is no white attack on the kingside so Black can look forward to the long-term prospects of a minority attack on the queenside) 11...♖ae8 12 h3 ♗xf3 13 ♖xf3 e5 (the common strike for Black once White has done something funny in the opening) 14 ♗h5 ♗xh5 15 ♖xh5 g6 16 ♖d1 exd4 with advantage to Black.

A) 6 h3!?



White's aim is clear: to prevent Black from developing his light-squared bishop to g4. Of all the variations in this chapter, this is probably the most annoying for the unprepared; it is annoying if you have no idea where to put the light-squared bishop. There are, however, some drawbacks to White's sixth move: the first is that White takes time out in the opening to make a little pawn move, so Black might strike out with the enterprising ...e7-e5. The second benefit for Black is that as the white kingside has been slightly weakened, the plan of ...g7-g6 followed by ...♙f5 becomes a lot more attractive.

6...♘f6!

The most flexible move and now White must decide what to do with his knight on g1:

A1) 7 ♘e2

A2) 7 ♘f3

With 7 ♘d2 White does not control any central squares so our reaction is standard: 7...e5!. Black should not worry about the resulting IQP since he will have easy piece play. We should also bear in mind that White's weaknesses are on the b1-h7 diagonal and note that we have strong squares on e4 and c4. These may become important later on. Following 8 dxe5 ♘xe5 9 ♙c2 ♙c5 10 ♘b3 (E.Geller-Y.Razuvaev, USSR Championship, Minsk 1979) 10...♙d6 11 ♘f3 0-0 12 0-0 ♙e8 13 ♙e3 (or 13 ♙g5 ♘e4 14 ♙e3 ♘c4 15 ♙xd5 ♘f6 16 ♙d4 ♘xe3 17 fxe3 ♙e6 when Black's two bishops along with the heavy pressure against the weak e3-pawn give him good compensation for the pawn) 13...♙d7 14 ♘xe5 ♙xe5 15 ♙d3 a6 is equal.

Instead, 7 ♙e2? ♘xd4 nets a pawn.

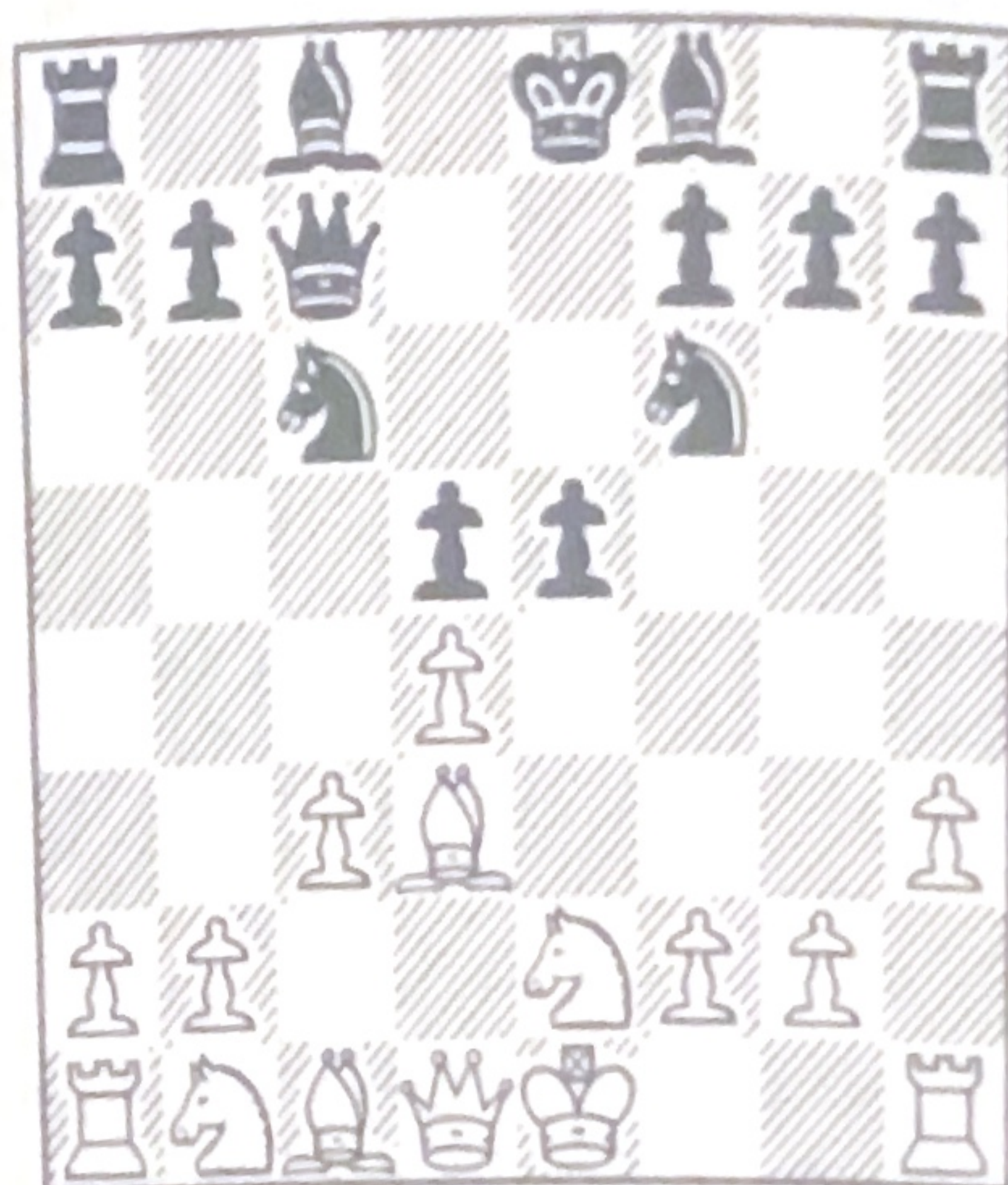
A1) 7 ♘e2

This is aimed at making ...g6 less favourable as Black will not be able to swap off the bad

light-squared bishop. However, White is relinquishing control over the e5-square, so I believe Black should abandon his strategic ideas and opt for active play in the centre.

Remember: No control over the centre? Play ...e7-e5!

7...e5!



8 dxe5 ♗xe5 9 ♖c2

White here has a variety of other moves to choose from:

If 9 ♖e3?! ♗d6 10 ♖d4 a6! (there is no way we will ever allow White to play ♗b5, exchanging the bishop) 11 0-0 0-0 12 ♖c2 (if 12 ♖f5 ♖xf5 13 ♖xf5 ♗c4) 12...♗c4! (as mentioned before, Black makes use of the strong squares) 13 ♖c1 ♖e8 14 ♖d2 b5 15 ♗d3 ♗e4 16 ♗d3 ♖b8! (with the beautiful idea of a rook lift along the sixth rank to aid a potential kingside attack; instead, 16...♖b7 was played in B.Giulio-A.Rasmussen, Dresden Olympiad 2008) 17 ♖b1 ♖b6 18 b3 ♗e5 19 ♗xe5 ♖xe5 and Black has tremendous piece coordination.

b) 9 ♖b5+ can be met with the natural 9...♗d7 10 ♖xd7+ ♗xd7 11 ♗g3 ♗d6 12 0-0-0 13 ♖g5 ♗e4! 14 ♗xe4 dxe4 15 ♖d2 f5 and Black has not only the superior pawn structure, but an outpost on d3 for his knight, A.Bilgin-R.Bigaliev, Istanbul 2010.

c) 9 ♖f4 is, of course, met with 9...♗d6 10 ♖xe5 ♖xe5 11 ♖d2 0-0 12 0-0 ♖h2+ (standard technique to push the king one square away) 13 ♖h1 ♗d6 14 ♖d4 a6 15 ♖e1 ♗d7.



Jobava now handled the black side of the position very impressively: 16 ♖f3 ♜ae8 17 ♜f5 ♜e5 (17...♜xf5 18 ♜xf5 ♜b6 would be a safer method) 18 ♜b3 g6 19 ♜fd4 ♜b6 20 ♜e2 ♜b8 21 ♜xe8 ♜xe8 22 ♜f1 h5 23 ♜c5 ♜xh3 24 ♜a4 ♜d6 25 ♜xh3 ♜e4 26 ♜g1 ♜f4 27 ♜f3 ♜a7 0-1, E.Krivoborodov-B.Jobava, Moscow 2008.

d) 9 ♜d4 doesn't really promise anything. Black may have an isolated pawn, but he has a strong square for his knight on e4 and the bishops: 9...♜xd3+ 10 ♜xd3 ♜c5 11 0-0 0-0 12 ♜e3 a6 13 ♜d2 ♜e8 14 ♜fe1 ♜d7 15 ♜c2 ♜d6 16 ♜d4 (16 ♜g5 ♜b5 17 ♜f3 ♜e4 is slightly better for Black too) 16...♜h5 and although the game ended in a draw in A.Semeniuk-P.Maletin, Vladivostok 2012, Black stands a bit better on account of his superior piece activity.

9...♜d6 10 ♜g5

After 10 ♜d4 a6 (of course, self-explanatory) 11 0-0 0-0 12 ♜f5 ♜xf5 13 ♜xf5 ♜fe8 14 ♜d2 ♜ad8 15 ♜f3 h6 16 ♜d4 ♜c4 Black has no problems; his knights have good posts and the dark-squared bishop is on an excellent diagonal.

10...♜e4



11 ♖e3 O-O

A cool retort. 11...♟f6 and 11...♙e6 are more boring ways of playing the position.

12 ♜xd5

If 12 ♟f4 ♙f5 13 ♟xd5 ♜c6 14 ♟f4 ♟c4 with advantage to Black.

12...♟f6 13 ♜d4 ♟c4 14 ♙g5.

After 14 ♟d2 ♟xe3 15 ♜xe3 ♙d7 16 O-O ♙b5 17 ♜fe1 ♜fe8 18 ♜f3 ♜e7 19 ♙d3 ♙c6 20 ♜f5 ♜ad8 Black has huge compensation for the pawn as White can hardly move a piece: for instance, 21 ♟c4 ♙b8 and Black is lining up an attack on the dark squares.

14...♙e5 15 ♜h4 h6 16 ♙xf6 ♙xf6 17 ♜e4 g6 18 ♙b3

Not 18 O-O? which drops a piece to 18...♙f5.

18...b5!



19 ♜xa8 ♙b7 20 ♜xa7

Alternatively, 20 ♜xf8+ ♙xf8 21 O-O ♟xb2 22 ♟d2 ♜d7 and the knight on d2 doesn't have a good home.

20...♜a8 21 ♜xa8+ ♙xa8

Again Black's lead in development gives him a very pleasant position.

22 O-O ♟xb2 23 ♟d2 ♜d7

Black wins back his material with the upper hand.

A2) 7 ♖f3



White's main move.

7...g6!

Of course, the bishop must be developed.

8 0-0

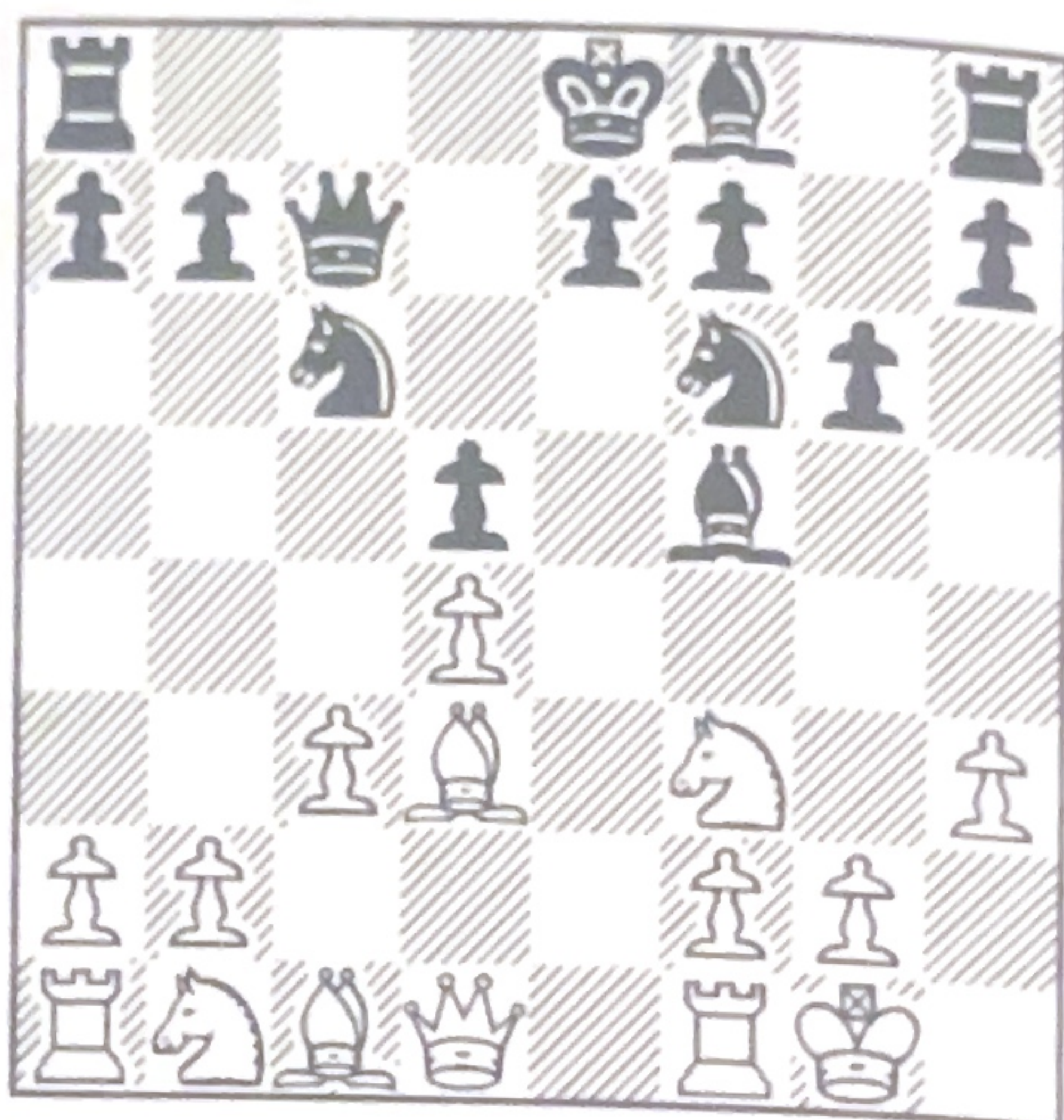
8 ♖c2 looks like good prophylaxis against Black's planned ...♗f5, but we have a crafty trick up our sleeve: after castling we can play ...♘h5-f4 and chase away the bishop. 8...♗g7 9 0-0 0-0 leads to:

a) I like that even after 10 ♗g5 that Black can stick to the plan with 10...♘h5.



After 11 ♖d2 f6 12 ♗e3 e5 13 g4 e4! 14 ♗e2 (if 14 gxh5 exd3 15 h6 ♗h8 16 ♖g2 ♖b6 17 ♗e1 ♗e7 18 ♗xd3 ♖e6 19 ♖h1 ♗f5 and White is struggling with his open king) 14...exf3 15 ♗xf3 f5 16 gxh5 f4 17 ♗xd5+ ♗h8 18 hxg6 ♗xh3 19 ♗g2 ♗xg2 20 ♖xg2 f3+ White was being killed in D.Pershin-M.Matlakov, St Petersburg 2013. Impressive play.

- b) If 10 ♙e3 Black needs to be a bit smarter and play 10... ♙e6! (waiting for White to develop the queen's knight) 11 ♞bd2 (if 11 ♞g5 ♙d7 and White's best move is to retreat the knight) 11... ♞ac8! 12 ♞ac1 ♞h5 and now White has no way of preventing ... ♞f4 .
 c) 10 ♞e1 ♞h5 11 ♙e3 ♞f4 12 ♙f1 ♙f5 with equality.
 8... ♙f5! ?



At first sight it looks very strange to double the pawns in this manner. There is a great deal of logic behind this idea, though: Black secures the central e4-square, opens the g-file for his rooks and leaves White lumbered with a bad bishop. I also happen to think that this is the best move order as White is not given time to play ♞e1 and hide the bishop on f1.

9 ♞e1

9 ♙xf5?! gxf5 only helps Black:

a) 10 c4 (directly challenging Black's set-up) 10... ♙g7 11 ♞c3 ♞d8 12 ♞b5 (or 12 ♞b3 dxc4 13 ♞xc4 e6 and I don't see any problems for Black) 12... ♞b8 13 cxd5 (13 g3 is the kind of move my students face all the time; after 13... dxc4 14 ♙f4 ♞c8 15 ♞c7+ ♙f8 Black is threatening ... ♞h5 , winning material) 13... ♞xd5 14 ♞h4 e6 15 ♙g5 ♞d7 16 ♞f3 0-0 (it might have been worth throwing in the move 16...h6 first) 17 ♞d2 ♞f6 18 ♙h6 was agreed drawn in Z.Efimenko-A.Riazantsev, Olginka 2011.

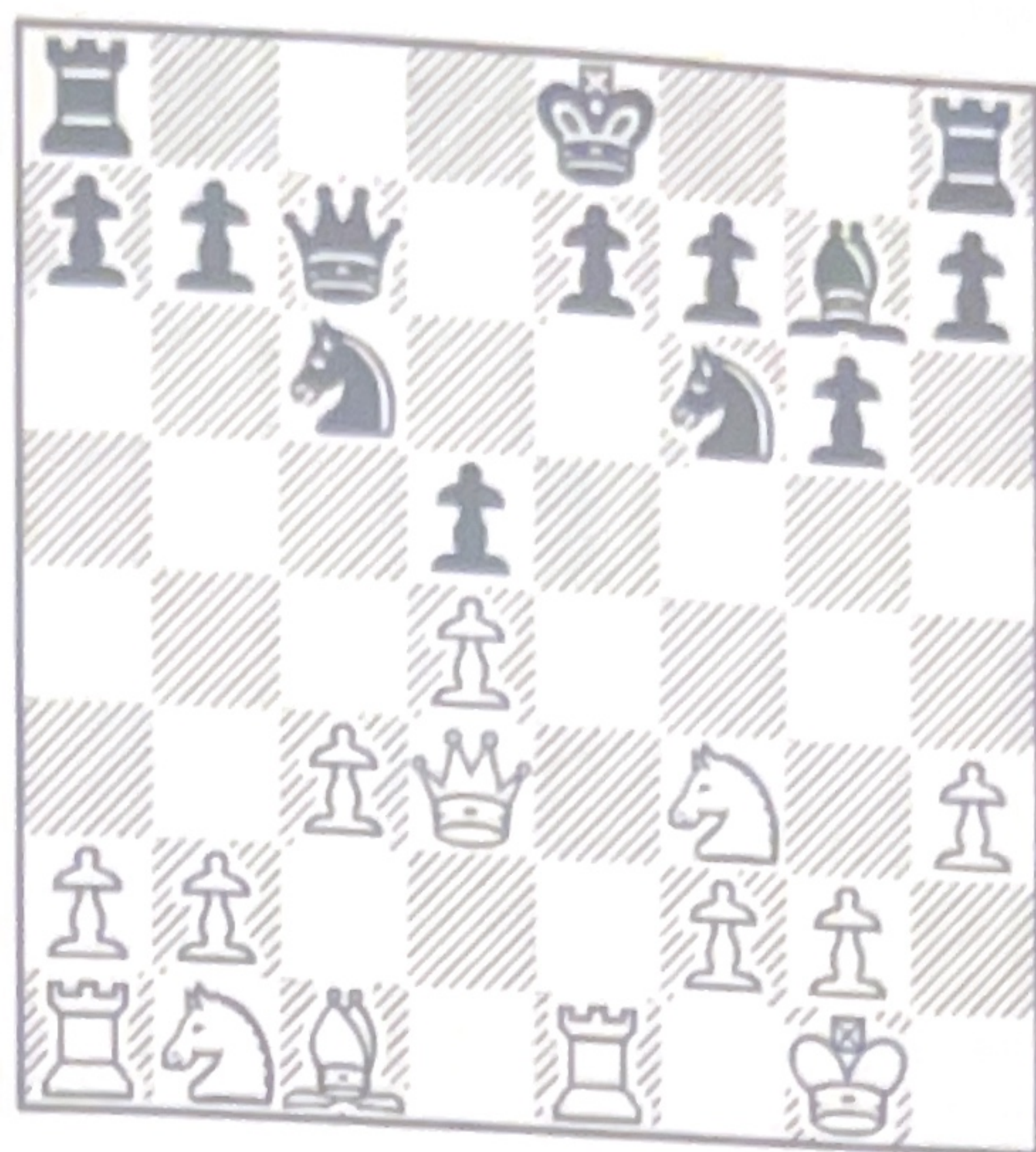
b) 10 ♙g5 ♞e4! 11 ♞c1 f6 12 ♙f4 e5 13 ♙h2 0-0-0 14 b4 f4 and Black is much better, L.Donovan-Q.Ducarmon, Belgian League 2012.

c) 10 ♞e2 might be the best try with the idea of a quick c3-c4: 10...e6 11 c4 dxc4 12 ♞xc4 0-0-0 13 ♞c3 ♞g8 14 ♙g5 (14 ♞d1 ♞d5 15 ♙g5 ♙e7 16 ♞b5 ♞b6 17 ♙xe7 ♞dxe7 is a double-edged position where Black should be okay) 14... ♙e7 15 ♞ac1 ♞d5 16 ♙xe7 ♞dxe7 17 ♞b5 ♞b6 18 ♞e5 a6 19 ♞c3 ♞xd4 20 ♞xd4 ♞xd4 21 ♞xf7 ♞g6 and Black has the better coordination with ... ♞f4 on the way.

9... ♙xd3!

This is an important move since after the natural 9... ♙g7? 10 ♙xf5 gxf5 11 ♞h4! it is difficult for Black to defend the f5-pawn.

10 ♖xd3 ♗g7



11 ♗bd2

Black has no problems after 11 ♗g5 0-0 12 ♗bd2 ♖ac8 13 ♖e3 (both 13 ♗f1 and 13 ♗b3 are well met by 13...♗e4) 13...♖fe8. His long-term aim is to begin a minority attack on the queenside, exploiting the fact that he can make use of the semi-opened c-file. White, on the other hand, will try and make use of the important e5-square while trying to chip away at the black king.

Likewise, after 11 ♗e5 0-0 12 ♗f4 ♖b6 13 ♗d2 e6 Black has a solid position.

11...0-0 12 ♗e5

This can be taken. Instead, after 12 ♗b3 Black should make some useful developing moves: for example, 12...e6 13 a4 ♖fe8 14 g3 ♗e4! 15 ♗f4 ♖d8 16 h4 h6 17 ♗g2 g5! 18 hxg5 hxg5 19 ♗e3 f5 (Black's position is a beautiful picture) 20 ♗g1 ♖f6 21 ♗e2 ♖ad8 22 f3 ♗d6 and Black had the upper hand in R.Ponomarev-Le Quang Liem, Dortmund 2010.

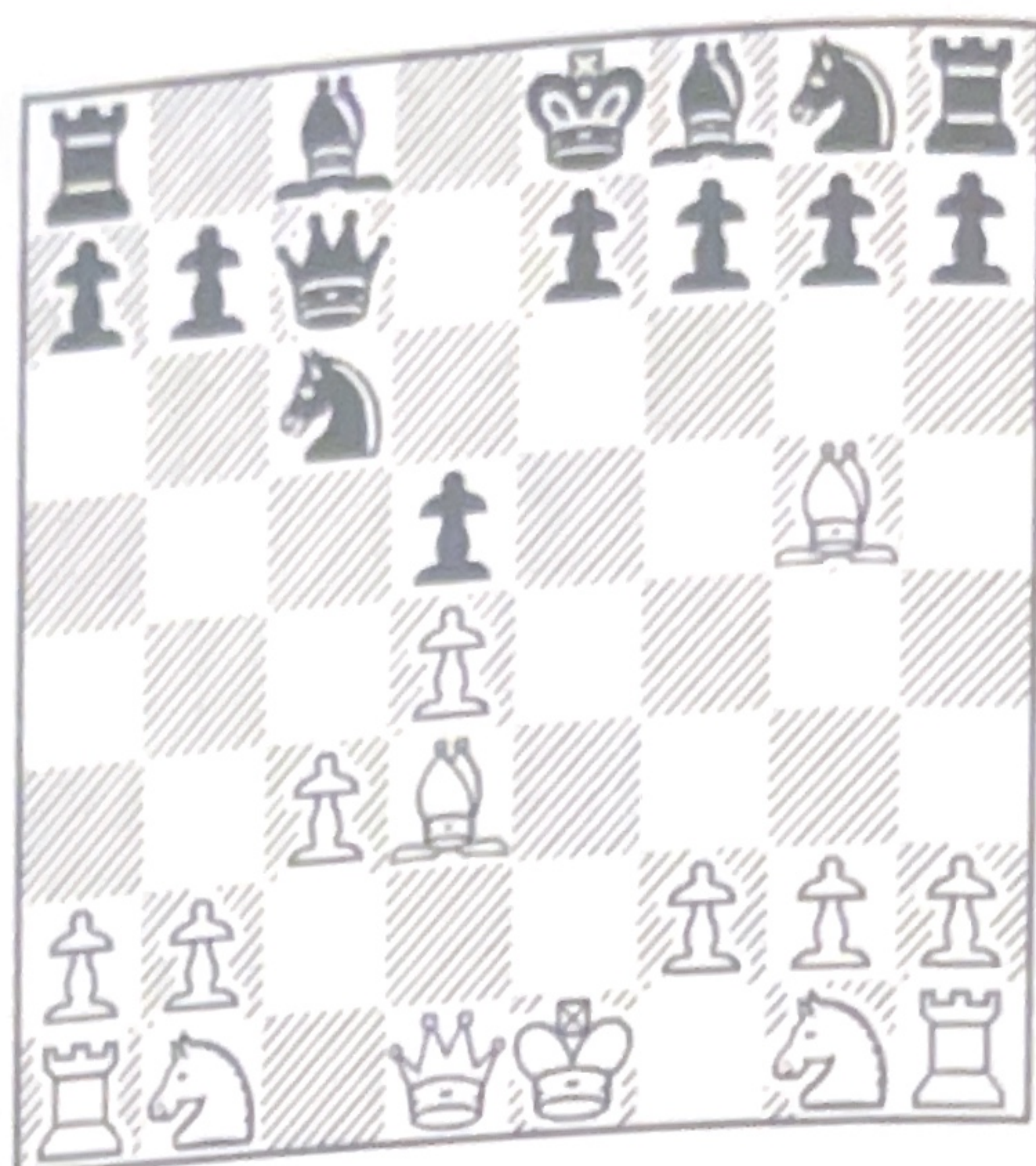
12...♗xe5 13 dxe5 ♗d7 14 ♗f3

14 e6 is not promising as after 14...fxe6 15 ♖xe6 ♗c5 16 ♖xd5 ♗xe6 Black has the advantage.

14...e6 15 ♗f4 ♖fc8 16 ♖e2 ♖ab8 17 ♖e3 b5

Black has handled the position perfectly. White has no play in the centre and now the play on the queenside gives Black the easier position, E.Jonsson-E.Thingstad, Stockholm 2012.

B) 6 ♗g5



I would describe this as the classical approach. White is primarily interested in achieving good development and securing harmonious squares for his knights.

6... ♖f6!

This move may be surprising since Black voluntarily offers to give himself doubled pawns, but should White choose to exchange he will be giving Black a helping hand in establishing a nice pawn centre. White has played several moves here:

B1) 7 ♗xf6?!

B2) 7 ♖d2

There's also:

a) 7 ♖f3 ♗g4 8 ♖bd2 transposes to Line B2, as, indeed, would 6 ♖f3 ♖f6 7 ♗g5 ♗g4 8 ♖bd2.

b) It dawned on me that White might also play 7 h3. Now I think that Black should be bold and strike out: 7...e5!? (7...h6 followed by ...e7-e5 is also acceptable) 8 dxe5 ♗xe5+ 9 ♗e2 ♗c5 10 ♗xe5+ ♖xe5 11 ♗b5+ ♗d7, and if 12 ♗xf6 gxf6 13 ♗e2 ♗g8 Black will follow up with ...d5-d4.

c) 7 ♗b3 is also met with the pawn push 7...e5! (the rule, the rule!) 8 ♖d2 (8 dxe5 hands Black the advantage after 8...♗xe5+ 9 ♗e3 ♗c5! and 8 ♖e2?! leaves the white bishop on d3 with no good squares; after 8...e4 9 ♗b5 a6 10 ♗xc6+ bxc6 Black has a nibble based on the bishop-pair) 8...e4! 9 ♗c2 ♗e6 and White has problems with his queen.

d) If 7 ♗h4 I like 7...e5 as 8 ♗g3 doesn't really pose a problem because of 8...♗d6.

e) 7 ♖e2 allows Black to develop the bishop, so we should play 7...♗g4 8 0-0 e6 9 ♗c2 ♗h5! 10 ♗e1 (10 ♖d2 is a mistake because of 10...♗xe2 11 ♗xe2 ♖xd4 12 ♗a4+ ♖c6) 10...♗g6 11 ♖d2 ♗e7 with no problems.

B1) 7 Bxf6? ! gxf6 8 Wf3

White fails to prevent Black's planned break, but the damage has already been done. Likewise, after 8 Nd2 e5 9 Wh5 Le6 10 Ne2 O-O-O Black is doing well.

8... e5 ! 9 Wxf6

This doesn't work, but 9 Wxd5 Le6 10 Wf3 O-O-O 11 Ne2 exd4 ! also gives Black a tremendous position.

9... Bg8

Hitting the g-pawn.

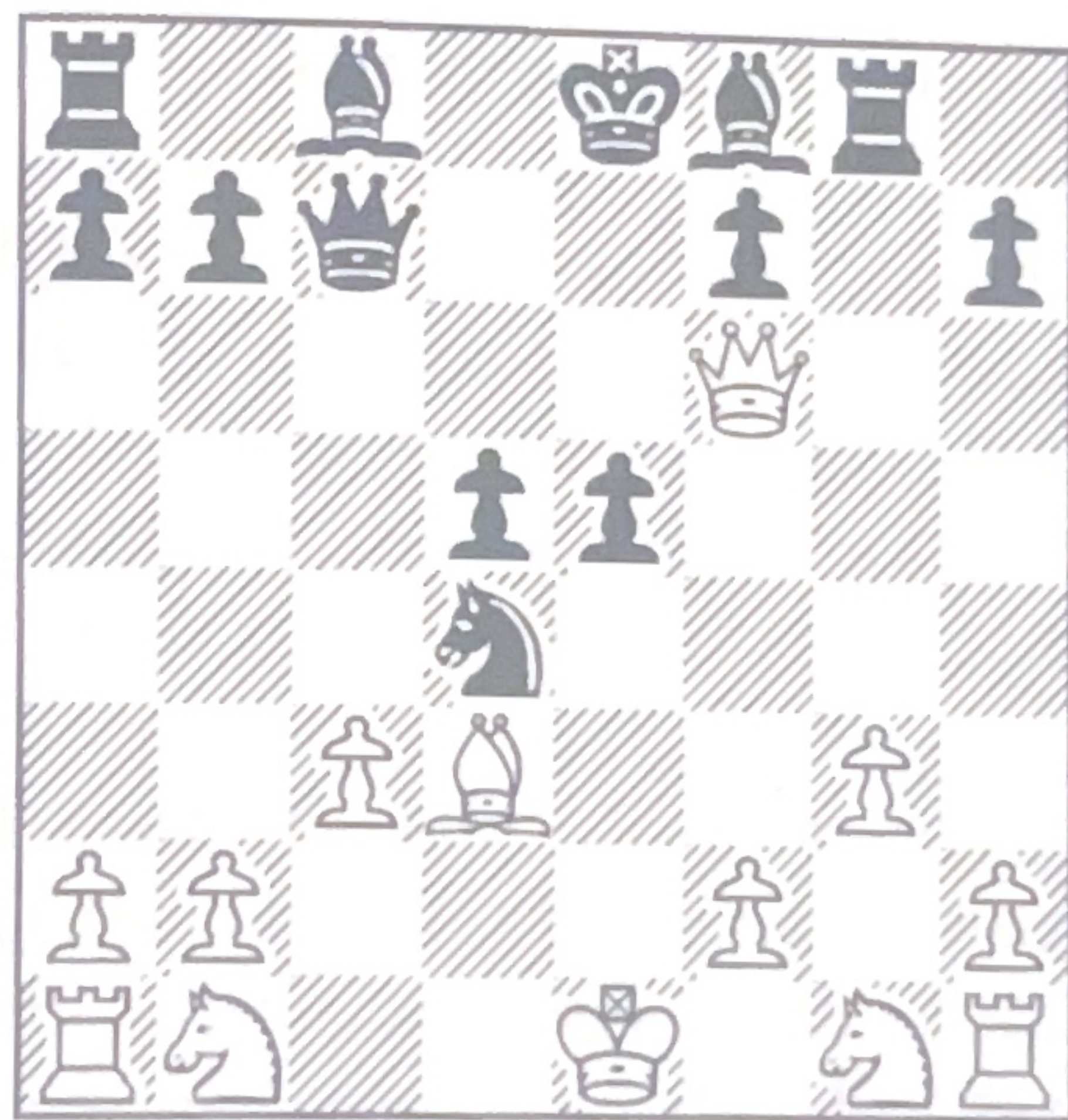
10 g3

Alternatively:

10 dxe5 does not help White either: 10... Wxe5+ 11 Wxe5+ Nxe5 12 Lf1 (White is forced backwards) 12... Lf5 13 Nd2 O-O-O 14 O-O-O Lc5 15 f3 Nd3+ 16 Lxd3 Lxd3 17 g3 Le3 and it is very difficult for White to develop without returning the extra pawn. For example, 18 Nh3 Le2 19 Rde1 Lxf3 and Black is much better.

b) 10 Lxh7 is equally horrendous after 10... Le7 11 Wf3 e4 , trapping the white bishop.

10... Nxd4 !



This is the tactical point.

11 cxd4 Wc1+ 12 Ke2 Wxb2+ 13 Nd2 e4 14 Bb1 exd3+ 15 Kf1 Wa3 16 Re1+ Le7

Black has a great position.

B2) 7 $\text{O}d2$ $\text{A}g4$ 8 $\text{A}gf3$

White plays in a very classical manner, but Black too has a very simple objective: neutralize the b1-h7 diagonal and play for a minority attack.

We should also consider:

a) 8 $\text{W}b1$?! has the aim of swapping the g4-bishop for a knight, but it's not so logical. I believe the best way to play against this is to follow the rule: 8...e5! 9 h3 $\text{A}d7$ 10 dxe5 $\text{W}xe5+$ 11 $\text{A}e3$ $\text{A}c5$ 12 $\text{A}gf3$ $\text{W}e7$ 13 0-0 (White erred with 13 $\text{W}d1$ $\text{A}xe3$ 14 $\text{A}e1$ 0-0 15 $\text{A}xe3$ $\text{W}d6$ 16 $\text{W}e1$ d4 when Black was doing very well in G.Sarakauskas-R.Ovetchkin, Plovdiv 2008) 13... $\text{A}xe3$ 14 $\text{A}e1$ $\text{A}xf2+$ 15 $\text{W}xf2$ $\text{A}e6$ and Black is a pawn up with a safe position.

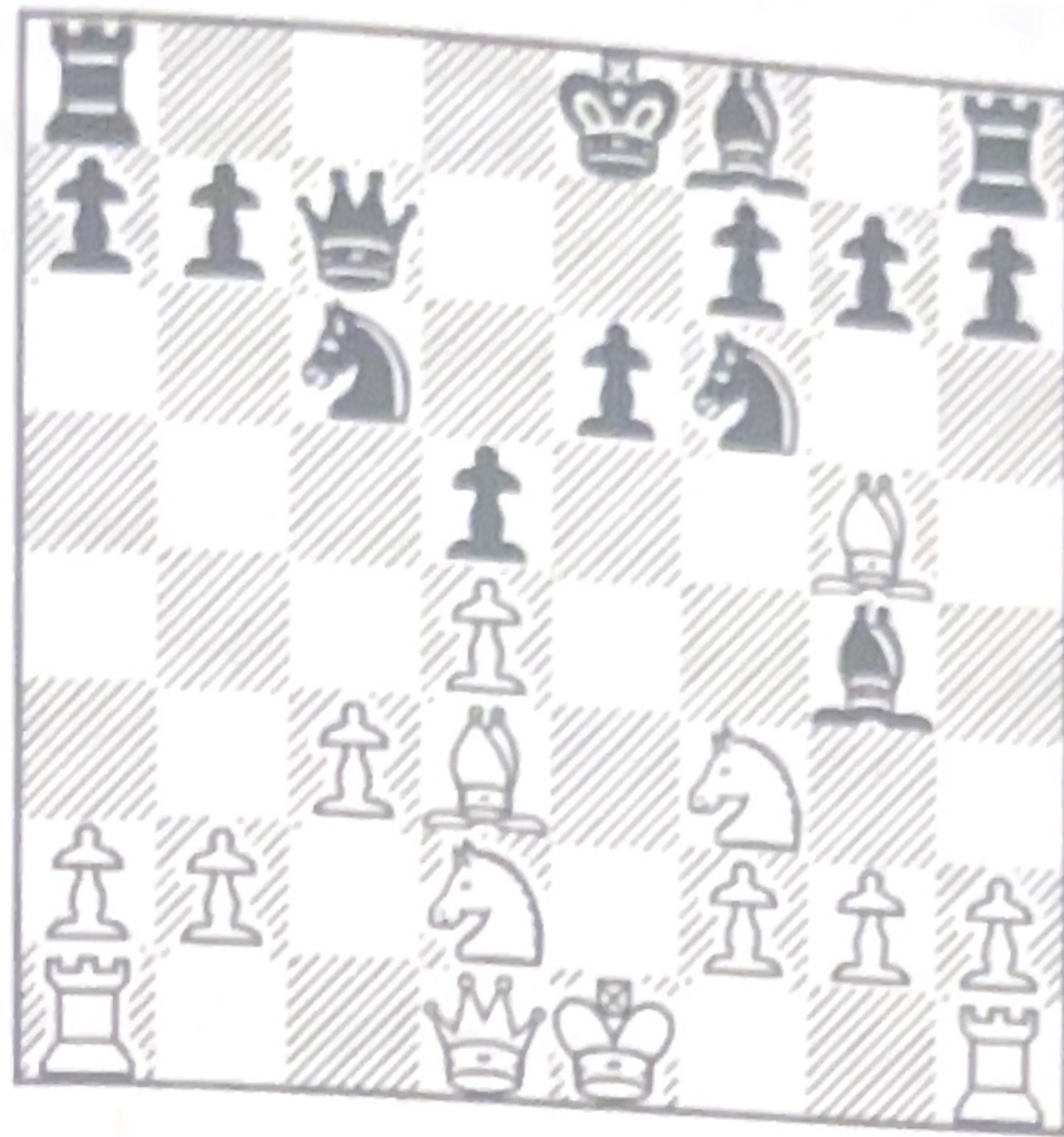
b) 8 $\text{W}a4$!? was played against me by IM Andrew Greet in a rapid game back in 2006. However, Black is doing fine after 8...e6 9 $\text{A}gf3$ $\text{A}d7$ (directed against $\text{A}e5$ ideas) 10 0-0 $\text{A}d6$ 11 $\text{A}h4$ $\text{A}h5$ 12 $\text{A}g3$ $\text{A}g6$ 13 $\text{A}b5$ $\text{A}xg3$ 14 hxg3 0-0 15 $\text{A}fe1$ $\text{A}fc8$ 16 $\text{A}e3$ a6 17 $\text{A}xc6$ $\text{W}xc6$ 18 $\text{W}b3$ h6 19 $\text{A}e5$ $\text{A}xe5$ 20 dxe5 b5 by when he has the standard plan of attacking the white queenside pawns.

c) 8 $\text{W}b3$ e6 (8...e5!? is also possible as 9 $\text{A}xf6$ gxf6 gives Black a slight advantage and 10 $\text{W}xd5$? is definitely not possible because of 10... $\text{A}d8$, regaining the pawn with some advantage) 9 $\text{A}gf3$ $\text{A}d6$ and Black continues in much the same way with 9... $\text{A}e7$ 10 0-0 $\text{A}d7$ 11 $\text{A}h4$ $\text{A}h5$ 12 $\text{A}g3$ $\text{A}g6$ 13 $\text{A}xd6$ $\text{W}xd6$ 14 $\text{A}e2$ 0-0.

d) 8 $\text{A}e2$ is really not a problem. Black simply retreats and goes 8... $\text{A}f5$ 9 $\text{A}gf3$ e6 10 $\text{A}h4$ $\text{A}d6$ (10... $\text{A}e7$ is also possible) 11 $\text{A}g3$ 0-0 12 $\text{A}xd6$ $\text{W}xd6$ 13 0-0 $\text{A}ab8$ 14 $\text{W}a4$ (M.Narciso Dublan-F.Peralta, Badalona 2009) 14...a6, planning a minority attack on the queenside.

e) 8 $\text{W}c2$ $\text{A}h5$ 9 $\text{A}h4$ e6 10 $\text{A}gf3$ $\text{A}d6$ 11 0-0 $\text{A}g6$, again with a reasonable position.

8...e6



Black has not faced any problems developing his pieces – this means we have a very normal position. The first concrete idea is to neutralize any potential kingside attack.

9 h3

h3 nudges Black to follow the correct plan of ...g4-h5-g6. Indeed, after 10 O-O d6 11 a4 (or 11 b3 O-O 12 fe1 ab8 13 a4 d7 14 g4 g6 15 xg6 hxg6 16 h4 a6 17 f1 b5 18 g3 b4 with the advantage for Black in L.Donovan-N.Eliet, Belgian League 2011) 11...g6 12 xg6 hxg6 13 fe1 O-O 14 e2 b5! (a common strike) 15 c2 ac8 16 d3 b4 17 c1 bxc3 18 xc3 b6 Black's control over the open c-line and White's weak d4-pawn hand Black an easy game, P.Tvarijonas-D.Fridman, Riga 2012.

Instead, after 9 O-O we can see the neutralization plan in action: 9...h5 10 e1 g6 11 e2 d6 12 f1 e4 13 e3 (A.Bitalzadeh-S.Ernst, Groningen 2006) 13...O-O 14 h4 a5 15 xg6 hxg6 16 d3 c4 17 xe4 dxe4 18 b3 b2 19 c2 d3 and Black is much better.

9...d6 10 g3 h5!



This manoeuvre is an important defensive idea. The idea is to swap off White's menacing light-squared bishop on d3. However, it is usually only a good idea to play ... Bg6 when (a) Black has not castled short and intends to go queenside, or (b) White has played h2-h3 , thereby preventing ideas of Bh3 and Bh4 . This is about the only special manoeuvre Black has to remember; everything else is straightforward.

11 Bxd6

With 11 O-O White intends Be1 followed by De5 , but after 11... Bxg3 12 hxg3 Bg6 13 Be2 (13 Bc2 ? fails to 13... Bb4 and 13 Bxg6 ? hxg6 plays into Black's hands; he will castle queenside and attack down the h-file) 13... Bxd3 14 Bxd3 O-O 15 Bfe1 Bac8 Black is fine.

11... Bxd6 12 O-O 13 Be1 Bab8

Intending to begin the queenside offensive.

14 a4 Bc7 15 Bb1 a6 16 De5 Bfe8 17 h3 Bg6 18 Bxg6 ! hxg6 19 Bd3 Dxe5 20 dxe5

Alternatively, 20 Bxe5 Bec8 with the idea of ... De8-d6-c4 .

20... Dd7 21 Bd4 Bec8 22 Be3 Bb6 ! 23 Bxb6 Dxb6

Black's position was the easier to play in M. Illescas Cordoba-V. Anand, Linares 1994.

C) 6 De2



With the aim of playing 7 Bf4 .

6... Bg4 !

Solving the problem of the light-squared bishop.

7 f3

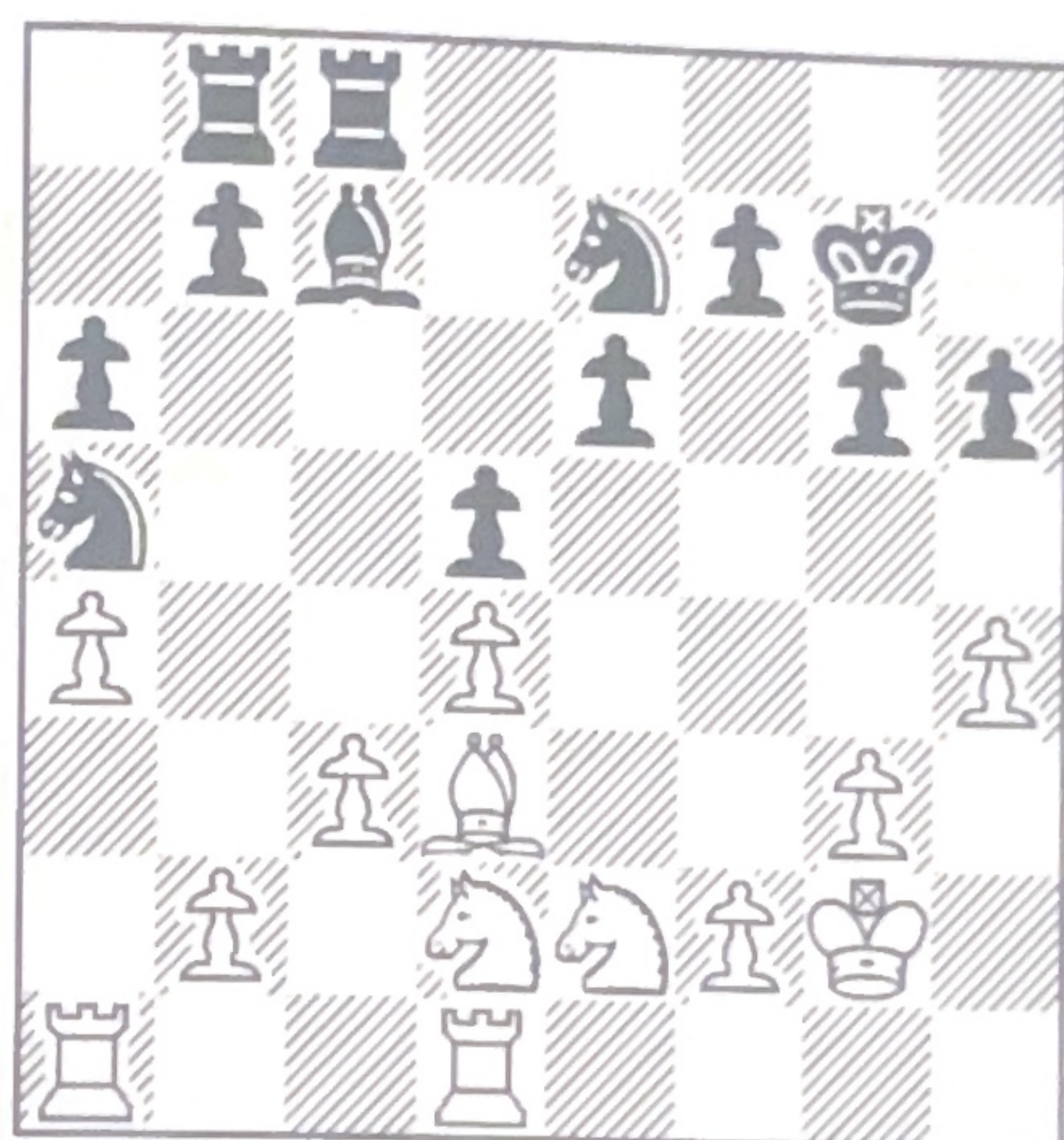
The most popular continuation. White does not want to see Black exchange the perceived 'bad' bishop for a knight that can in the future have influence over the e5-square.

Let's look at what happens if White avoids f2-f3 . There is one rule here: *when Dg3 is threatened, capture the knight on e2*:

a) 7 Bb3 Dxe2 ! (following the rule; Black does not want his bishop back on d7 and with one of the knights gone, he can rest safe in the knowledge that there is one less piece eye-

ing up the critical e5-square) 8 ♖xe2 ♜xd4 (a good route to equality, if a little drawish; 8...e6 9 ♞a3 ♞c8 is an alternative method of playing) 9 ♞xd5 and now instead of the original recommendation 9...♜xe2, I now like 9...♞d8 (the tempting 9...♜c2+? would lose immediately after 10 ♜d1 ♞d8 11 ♜b5+) 10 ♜b5+ ♜xb5 11 ♞xb5+ ♞d7 12 ♜e3 a6 13 ♞a4 ♜f6 14 ♜d2 ♜d5 when Black had easy development in J.Groz-S.Kojima, Cappelle-la-Grande 2011.

b) If White acts normally with 7 0-0 we go 7...e6 8 ♜f4 (8 f3 transposes to a position we'll see below, while after 8 ♞e1 ♜xe2! 9 ♞xe2 ♜f6 10 ♜d2 ♜d6 11 ♜f3 0-0 12 ♜g5 ♜d7 it's not very clear what White's plan will be, S.Vidovic-E.Dizdarevic, Sibenik 2009; Black, on the other hand, will play for the pawn break ...e6-e5 in order to activate his knights) 8...♞xf4 9 ♜xf4 ♜xd1 10 ♞xd1 ♜d6 11 ♜e2 ♜ge7 12 ♜d2 ♞b8 13 a4 0-0 14 ♜f3 ♞fc8 15 g3 a6 16 ♜g2 ♜a5 17 ♜d2 ♜c7 18 h4 h6 19 ♜f1 g6 20 ♜g2 ♜g7, as played in R.Gallego Martinez-J.Becerra Rivero, Andorra 1995.



Black eventually won the game by playing his knight to c4 and targeting White's Achilles' heel, the weak b2- and c3-pawns.

c) 7 h3 ♜xe2! (7...♜h5 is also possible, but after 8 ♞b3 Black must capture the knight because of the threatened ♜g3) 8 ♞xe2 ♜xd4 gave Black an easy game in Fan Yun-A.Ostrovsky, Philadelphia 2011.

d) 7 ♞a4 ♜xe2 (following the formula) 8 ♜xe2 e6 9 ♜g5 ♜e7 10 ♜xe7 ♜gxe7 11 ♜d2 0-0 12 ♞d1 e5 13 dxe5 d4 14 0-0 dxc3 15 bxc3 ♞xe5 16 ♞c1 ♞ad8 17 ♞e1 ♞fe8 and Black already had the upper hand in T.Heinemann-L.Nisipeanu, Hamburg 2012.

e) 7 f4 looks strange. Black should simply control the f5-square and get on with developing his pieces: 7...e6 8 0-0 ♜h6 9 ♜d2 ♜d6 10 ♜f3 ♜f5 11 ♜e5 ♜xd3 12 ♞xd3 ♜f5 13 ♜xc6 (or 13 g4 ♜fe7 14 ♜g3 0-0 15 g5 f6, breaking out) 13...♞xc6 14 ♜d2 h5 15 ♞ae1 0-0 16 ♞f3 b5 17 ♞h3 g6 18 ♞f3 ♜g7 19 ♜c1 ♞c4 20 ♜h1 b4 and Black's initiative on the queenside was more dangerous than White's stunted attack in D.Hiermann-G.Neff, Lienz 2011.

f) We should all know by now how to react to 7 ♞c2?: 7...♜xe2 and neither reply is good

due to the potential fork on d4.

g) 7 Qa3 was played against me once. Obviously Black should deal with the threat in question and play 7...a6! 8 Qc2 e6 9 Bf4 Bd6 10 Bxd6 Qxd6 11 f3 Bh5 12 Bg3 Bg6 13 0-0 Qe7 14 f4 Bxd3 15 Qxd3 g6 (following the rule of keeping f4-f5 under check) 16 Qe3 and now in M.Larsen-J.Houska, Harstad 2013, I was afraid that after 16...h5 17 f5 gxf5 18 Qgxf5 Qxf5 19 Qxf5 exf5 20 Qxf5 the position was not entirely clear, but simply 16...0-0 is fine for Black.

h) 7 Bf4 Qxf4 8 Qxf4 Bxd1 9 Qxd1 e6 10 Qd2 Bd6 11 Qh3 Qf6 and Black has no problems in the endgame.

i) 7 Qd2 e6 8 Qf1 with the idea of manoeuvring the queen's knight to g3 was an interesting try by GM Rozentalis. As White has, though, wasted some time with the knight, Black should simply retreat the bishop: 8... Bh5 9 Qfg3 Bg6 10 Qf4 Qf6 11 Qfh5 Qxh5 12 Qxh5 0-0-0 and Black has few problems with his development.

Finally, we can return to 7 f3:

7... Qd7



Now that Black has provoked a weakness, he retreats to safety. The critical question for both sides is when can Black strike out with the thematic and aggressive ...e7-e5.

Instead, 7... Bh5 ?! gives White the better position after 8 Bf4 !? Qb6 9 Qb3 ! (threatening to exchange queens and leave Black with weak doubled pawns) 9... Qxb3 10 axb3.

After the prudent text, we come to the main lines:

C1) 8 Qa3

C2) 8 Bf4

Otherwise:

a) 8 f4 is strange and Khenkin expertly demonstrated how to take advantage of the weak e4-square: 8...g6 9 Qd2 Qf6 10 Qf3 Bf5 ! 11 Qe5 Bxd3 12 Qxd3 e6 (preventing the

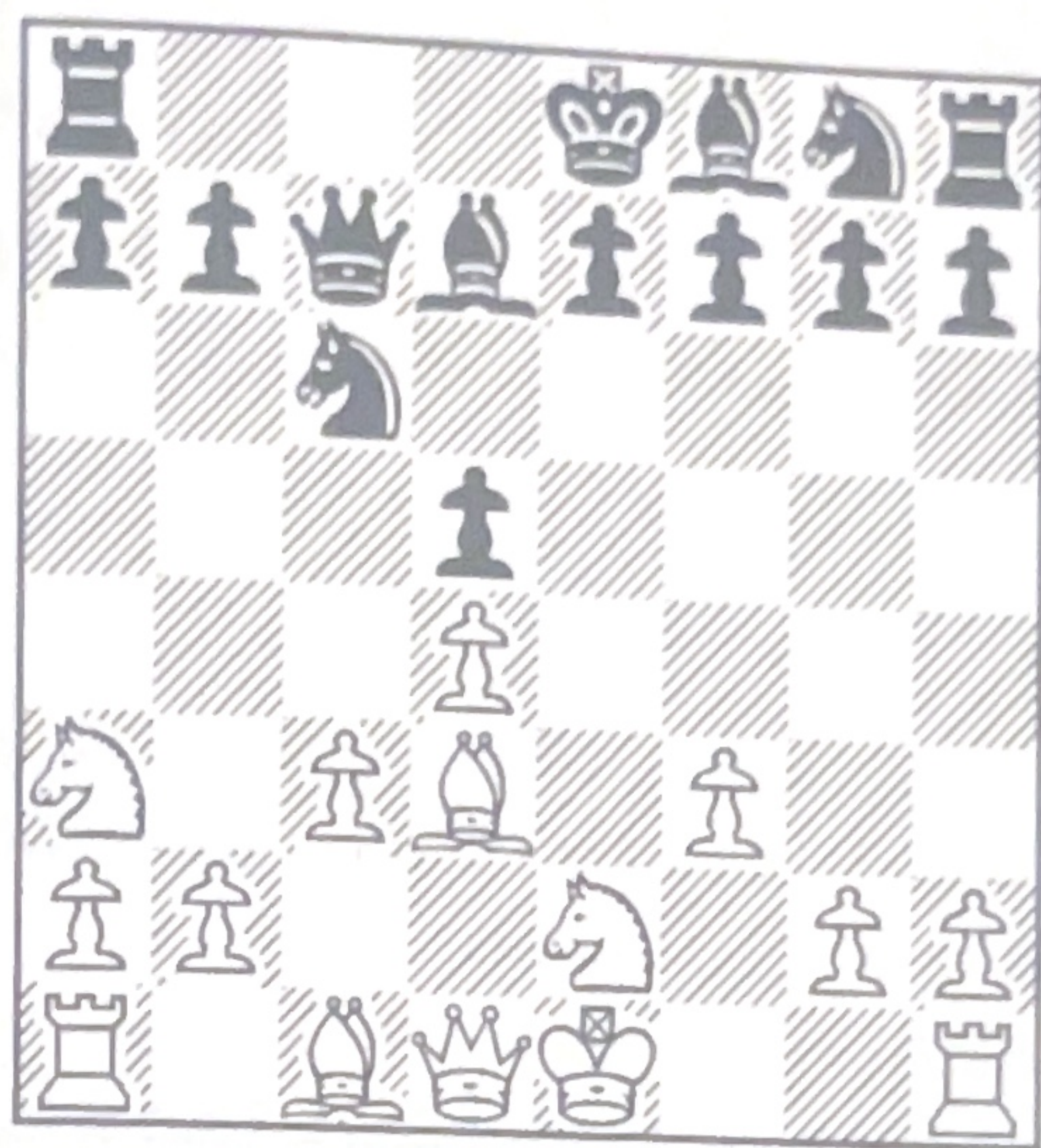
pawn push f4-f5) 13 ♖e3 ♙d6 14 0-0 ♜e7 15 ♜b5+ ♜f8 16 ♜ae1 h5 17 ♙c1 a6 18 ♜d3 b5 19 ♜h1 ♜g7 and White had no active plan in A.Panjkovic-I.Khenkin, Ortisei 2013.

b) 8 0-0 is perhaps a more serious try. I believe Black should respond in the most energetic way: 8...e5! 9 dxe5 ♜xe5 10 ♜d4 ♜xd3 11 ♜xd3 ♙d6 (the downside to playing an early f2-f3 begins to show) 12 f4 ♜e7 13 ♙e3 0-0 14 ♜d2 ♜fe8 15 g3 ♙c5 16 ♜2f3 ♜f5 17 ♙f2 ♙d6 and Black was much better in J.Blokhuis-F.Kroeze, Dutch League 2007.

c) 8 ♙g5 e5! 9 ♜d2 ♙d6 10 ♜b3 ♜ge7 11 ♜d2 f6 12 ♙h4 0-0 13 ♙g3 a5 was slightly better for Black in C.Cozianu-J.Benjamin, US Internet League 2010.

d) 8 ♜d2 is met with 8...e5!

c1) 8 ♙a3



This has the rather obvious idea of playing ♜b5 as well as of transferring the knight to e3 via c2.

8...a6 9 ♜c2

Alternatively:

a) If 9 ♜b3 Black should strike immediately with 9...e5! 10 ♜xd5 ♙e6 11 ♜e4 ♜f6 12 ♜h4 exd4! 13 cxd4 (13 ♜xd4 is inferior on account of 13...♜xd4 14 ♜xd4 ♙d8! and White has problems defending his pieces; here 15 ♜a4+ is harmless because of 15...b5 16 ♜xb5 axb5 17 ♙xb5+ ♙d7 18 ♙xd7+ ♜xd7 when the pawns are not worth the piece) 13...♙b4+ 14 ♜f2 ♜d8 (with the threat of winning the queen with ...♜g4+) 15 ♜g3 ♜xd4 and now 16 ♜xg7 is met with 16...♜g8.

b) 9 0-0 is the only move that dissuades Black from playing his planned ...e7-e5. Now I like 9...♜f6 10 ♜e1 (10 ♙g5 should be met with normal development and 10...e6, and 10 ♙f4 with the standard 10...e5!) 10...e6 11 ♙g5 ♙d6 12 g3 ♜c8. It may seem that White has gained a huge concession from Black in trapping the c8-bishop behind the e6-pawn, but White has weakened his king and has no natural piece coordination or plan. Indeed, 13 ♜c2 (if 13 ♙xf6 gxf6 14 ♜c2 h5 and Black will soon start an attack on the kingside) 13...h6

14 ♖xf6 gxf6 is slightly better for Black. His monarch is safe in the centre and he has a ready-made attack with ...h5-h4.

9...e5!



Energetic and effective.

10 dxe5

After 10 0-0 ♖d6 11 g3 ♜ge7 12 ♞e3 0-0 Black had a nicely centralized position in A.Kiriakopoulos-I.Simeonidis, Kallithea 2006. He will put the two rooks on the d- and e-files and continue putting pressure on the d4-pawn.

10...♜xe5 11 ♞cd4 ♖d6 12 ♞f5

This looks very tempting, but fails to trouble Black. That said, 12 ♖f5 ♞e7 13 ♖xd7+ ♜xd7 14 0-0 0-0 15 h3?! (weakening the dark squares) 15...♖c5 16 ♜h1 ♜fe8 17 f4?! ♞c4 is good for Black, J.West-J.Fang, Parsippany 2008.

12...♞xd3+ 13 ♜xd3 ♖xf5 14 ♜xf5 ♞e7 15 ♜g4



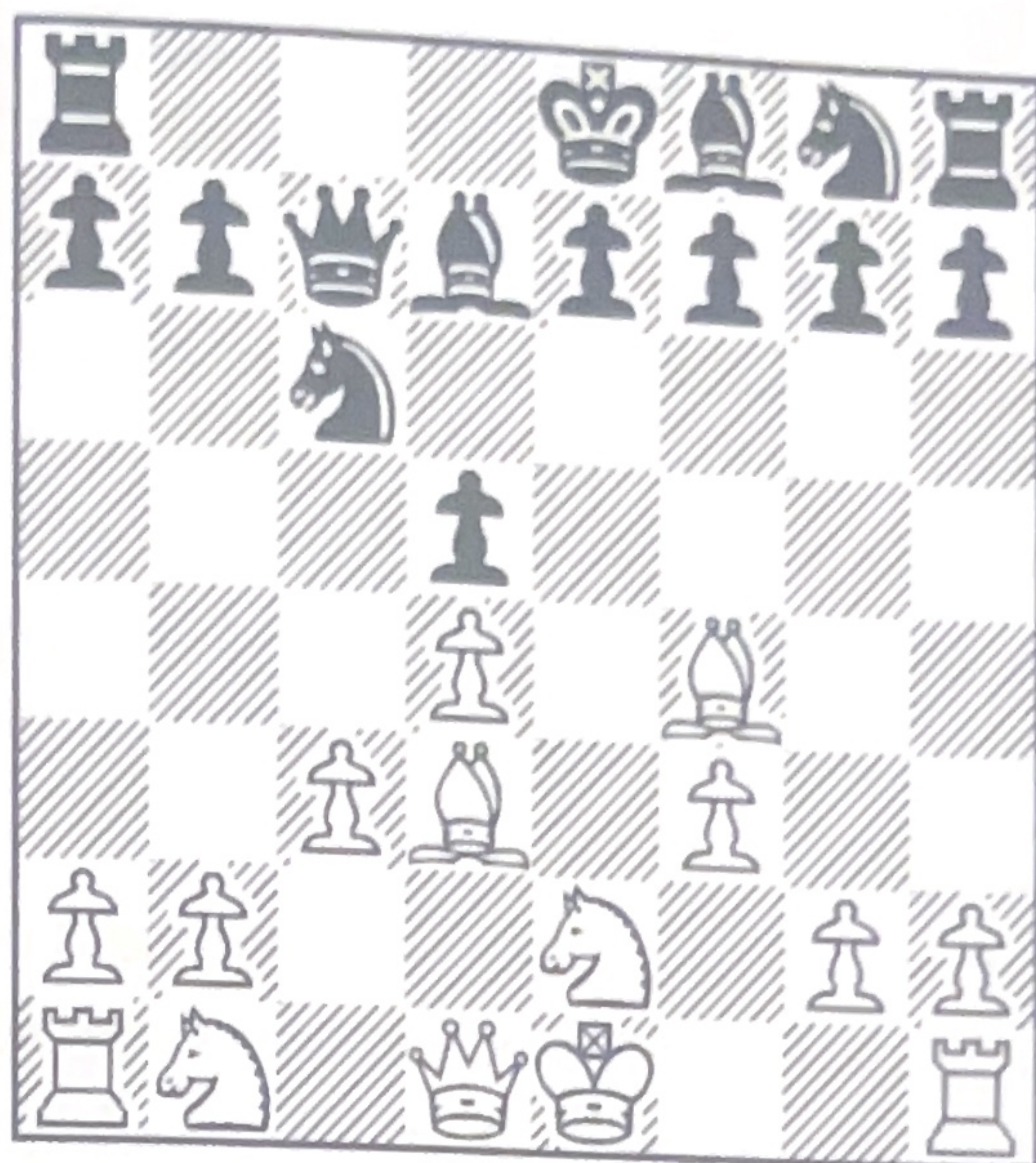
15... ♖g6!

This is designed to prevent White from exchanging pieces with ♗f4. Instead, 15...0-0 16 ♗f4 was equal in S.Khabarov-D.Svetushkin, Paleochora 2011.

16 ♗f4 0-0 17 0-0 ♖ae8 18 ♗g3 f5!

Striking out as after 19 ♗xf5?? ♜c8 20 ♗e3 ♜xg4 21 ♗xg4 ♗c5+ 22 ♔h1 h5! White loses material.

c2) 8 ♗f4



Obvious, but Black's play is now very energetic and, indeed, White must be careful not to emerge from the opening somewhat worse.

8...e5!

A good answer. This line has been played by several grandmasters, amongst them world-class players Alexei Dreev and Liviu-Dieter Nisipeanu. Now we have:

c21) 9 ♗g3?!

c22) 9 dxe5

c21) 9 ♗g3?!

A little too timid.

9...♗d6